Words Can Inspire or Destroy

Poems By Carlos Andres Gomez and Natasha T. Miller

INTRODUCTION

Words have power. Their meaning crystallizes perceptions that shape our beliefs, drive our behavior, and ultimately, create our world.

A 21st century Jewish Rabbi shared this striking statement: "Words are singularly the most powerful force available to humanity. We can choose to use this force constructively with words of encouragement, or destructively use words of despair. Words have the ability to help, to heal, to hinder, to hurt, to harm, to humiliate and to humble."

Today I offer these powerful words from Carlos Andres Gomez and Natasha T. Miller in a compilation I call Words can Inspire or Destroy.

Words Worth by Carlos Andres Gomez

they say:

"sticks and stones can break bones

– but words can never hurt"

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yet, I've seen stones and sticks

break lips and bones in hips

after words commanded such action

or seen violence in metaphor

or pushed in minds before

children were four years or four months old

now

tell me – what are words worth?

children learn about subject, object, and predicate

symbolically constructing sentences

in American classrooms

where white students are taught as subjects

while black students are treated like objects

destined to be subjected to life sentences

because of semantic switch-ups that set statutory

precedence

now

tell me – what are words worth?

and then…it comes to

naming

uniqueness is distorted to be invisibility

– instead of celebrating them

beautiful names like
asangaiso, owusu, or tokufu
become “that black kid over there”
become “that gangster over there”
become “that n*** – right there”
now
tell me – what are words worth?
then grammar school students
get ideology laced grammar lessons
memorizing
hegemonic definitions and connotations
through pictures and intonations
inflecting oppression with stapled tongues
and mute voice boxes
they start with socially constructed polarities
called antonyms
and end with
strategic synonyms
insidiously selling minds to white history
paid for with words
we tattoo into subconscious crevices of our consciences
and it all started for me with dichotomies

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framing opposed pairs
with the
“good” as the former
and the
“bad” as the latter:
good and evil
light and dark
white and black
pure and tainted
civilized and savage
and then I was fed
with “synonyms:”
progress equals betterment
brown equals primitive
fat equals undisciplined
poor equals stupid
law equals justice
now
tell me – what are words worth?
we’re brought up to believe in
adverbs that modify actions
– used to euphemize and pacify them

passive voicing third hand revisions
like “millions of native peoples were killed…unintentionally”
– not by anyone in particular – but they died
or slave owners were “understandably controlling”
or “necessarily brutal”
and before we know it
nouns are becoming pronouns
without the people’s consent
like polytheistic students reading about
one capitalized **G**od…
wondering which one overthrew the others
or Latinos learning of US anointing ourselves the
only **A**mericans
or me – watching a propagandized phrase
like “the **W**ar on **T**error”
granted legitimization through pronoun glory on CNN
now
tell me – what are words worth?
and some think these thoughts
apply only to English class
as if science and math
don’t derive from the same path –

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an American past
that bleeds the wrath
of Industrial class struggles
and oppressive fads
that teach us socioeconomics
in math class
to pare down graphs
placing pairs in graphs
writing paragraphs in SATs
about SUVs
so we see –
the rich as deserving
and
those in need as perturbing
now
tell me – what are words worth?
our father is named Uncle Sam
our teacher is named Webster
our slave-master is named English
my name was stolen
before I was born
by a language that wasn’t and isn’t mine

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Carlos Andres Gomez
Album: Fate by the Throat
ASIN: B001GQXTNC
Publisher: CD Baby
Date (Month/Year): 2008

Spoken Word lyrics can be found on-line only at
https://carlosandresgomez.tumblr.com/poems

TRANSITION

Now let's get a bit more specific about words: Author Doug Williford explains: If my spouse comes to me in obvious pain and asks the question, "Do you love me?", an answer of "I love everyone," would be truthful, but also hurtful and cruel in the moment... So when a person of any race speaks up in a time of obvious pain and hurt and says, "Black lives matter," a response of "All lives matter," is truthful. But it is also hurtful and cruel in the moment. Natasha T. Miller further explains in her poem "Ten Things You Sound Like…"

Ten Things You Sound Like When You Say 'all lives matter' in Response to Black Lives Matter by Natasha T. Miller

1. You invite me to a breast cancer awareness walk to honor your late auntie. I arrive wearing all red. You tell me that the colors are pink . . . and I say I know, but I don't see the point in breast cancer awareness having its own walk when people are dying of AIDS too.
2. Your family pet goes missing. You post pictures of it all around your neighborhood. I come and post pictures of other people's missing pets from around the world on top of the picture of your pet . . . well . . . because . . . you're not the only one missing a pet.
3. I show up to your grandmother's funeral and hand out my grandmothers' obituaries. You ask why. Because you ain't the only one that lost a grandma.
4. I go into a hospital and change all the intensive care unit signs to care unit signs because every life in the hospital should be cared for just the same. What makes intensive care unit patients think that their lives matter more than the life of Jenny on the first floor fighting a cold? Colds can kill too.
5. Your fiancé stands you up at the altar. As you're crying, I get up and yell millions of people get broken up with every day. Stop whining.
6. I show up at the Alcoholics Anonymous meeting to get help for my cotton candy addiction. An addict is an addict. We all deserve help.

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7. You say Caylee Anthony. I saw what about her, we still don't know who killed little JonBenet.
8. I say Black lives matter. You say you don't see color.
9. I say Dallas. You say blue lives matter. I say I thought you didn't see color.
10. It sounds like when I say Black lives matter, and you say all lives matter.
    It sounds like when I say Black lives matter, and you say all lives matter.
    It sounds like when I say Black lives matter, you say all lives matter.

It sounds racist. It sounds inhumane. It sounds like all lives matter, but when I say: (**Names added for recency*)

*Daunte Wright
*George Floyd
*Breonna Taylor
Tamir Rice
Trayvon Martin

You say nothing.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Natasha T. Miller
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Find out more about the individuals mentioned in this poem here:
https://www.bbc.com/news/world-us-canada-52905408

(from 1st poem)

now

tell me – what are words worth?

words are powerful
words are oppressive
words are liberating
words are ideology
and hegemony
and stories
and culture
words…are priceless
but often undervalued
poured out endlessly with little thought
but ***always*** at a cost

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so think before you talk…

and make sure

it's worth it

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